

CASE BRIEF: CALDER v. PINE STREET LABS, INC.

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Calder v. Pine Street Labs, Inc., Fictional Court of Appeals of Franklin, decided May 18, 2026.

Facts. Pine Street Labs, Inc. operated a subscription analytics platform for independent pharmacies. Elena Calder, a former regional sales director, alleged that Pine Street failed to pay earned quarterly commissions after she resigned. Calder's commission plan stated that commissions were "earned when the customer pays the first annual invoice" and that employees must be "actively employed on the scheduled payout date" unless termination occurred without cause.

Procedural History. Calder filed suit for breach of contract, violation of the Franklin Wage Payment Act, and unjust enrichment. The trial court granted summary judgment to Pine Street, reasoning that Calder was not employed on the payout date and therefore had no right to payment. Calder appealed.

Issue. Whether an employer may withhold commissions that were earned before resignation based solely on an active-employment condition tied to a later payout date.

RULE AND ANALYSIS

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Rule. Under the Franklin Wage Payment Act, wages include commissions that are calculable and earned under an employment agreement. A contractual condition may define when a commission is earned, but a forfeiture provision is unenforceable if it requires an employee to surrender compensation already earned for completed work.

Analysis. The court distinguished between earning conditions and payment timing. Pine Street's plan required customer payment of the first annual invoice before commissions were earned. The record showed that three customers paid their first annual invoices before Calder resigned. For those accounts, Calder had completed the work and the contractual earning condition had occurred.

The active-employment clause controlled the scheduled payout date, not the earning date. The court held that applying the clause to forfeit earned commissions would conflict with the Wage Payment Act. However, Calder was not entitled to commissions for two customers who signed order forms before her resignation but did not pay invoices until after she left, because the earning condition had not occurred.

HOLDING AND DISPOSITION

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Holding. The court held that Pine Street could not withhold commissions earned before Calder's resignation merely because she was not employed on the later payout date. The court also held that commissions were not earned for accounts where customer payment occurred after resignation.

Disposition. The judgment was reversed in part and affirmed in part. The case was remanded for calculation of commissions on the three accounts paid before Calder's resignation, statutory interest, and reasonable attorney's fees.

Reasoning. The court emphasized that wage statutes are interpreted broadly to protect compensation for completed work. Employers may set objective earning conditions, but they may not transform a payment schedule into a forfeiture of wages after the employee has satisfied those conditions.

Notes. This fictional case brief is for software testing only and does not describe a real court, jurisdiction, party, or legal ruling.